

market size for kids (12-16 years) in urban areas is estimated to be Rs 15,000 crore. The total market size of apparel for kids (12-16 years) in urban areas is estimated to be Rs 1,600 crore, which is growing at 25-30 per cent per annum.

If fitness is finding currency among the parents, fitness gurus and kindergartens are joining hands to launch kids' gyms. Fitness expert Leena Mogre has partnered with a playschool chain called Tree House to start fitness centres for children between four and 11 years. The gym has five centres in Mumbai with around 70 students.

Explaining the need for such gyms, Mogre says: "Ideally, children should play in the natural environment, but in the absence of playgrounds and

parks, most kids end up staying at home. The age between four and 11 is the concept-forming age when children should get used to the idea of fitness so that when they grow up, fitness becomes their second nature."

The gym has special equipment, which function on hydraulic pressure pumps. They are to make the body proportional and are not for muscle building, stresses Mogre. The treadmills, elliptical trainers and rowing machines are all manual and don't use electricity. And for those parents who cannot identify with the concept of a gym, Rajesh Bhatia, the managing director of Tree House Education has more activities like karate, dance and music on offer. Says Bhatia: "The place is not just a gym, it's an activity centre for those who want to opt for other things."

But aping adults can prove harmful for kids. Child specialists and orthopaedics object to the use of dumbbells, no matter how light. "A young child's body is not ready to take on changes that exercise can cause. It could lead to muscle tear and injuries," says orthopaedic surgeon Dr Suryakant Kulkarni. He explains that young bones are tender and when subjected to exercise can even harm skeletal growth, a fear which has probably resulted in the concept of kids' gyms not picking up in the country.

Recently, the high-end fashion brand for children between 0-14 years entered India through Major Brands. The French brand starts at Rs 500 and goes up to Rs 3,000 and follows the trends straight from the runways of Paris. Says Suresh D Bhatia, director, Major Brands, "Today's children have assertive personalities. They evolve quickly and no longer want to be seen in specific kids stores, but rather prefer to shop at stores where 'fashion' is sold."

It's not just the apparel companies that are bending over backwards to cater to the little masters, even regular Spas and Salons are riding the brat-wagon by offering freebies and special party packages to their clients' children. Evidently, the world is a beautiful place for the grooming industry, where both the old and the young come seeking the elixir of life.

concentrate on school and come back in a couple of years." Adds socialite Queenie Dhody, "I started modelling at 19, which was young then but today that's considered very old."

It's not just the cosmetic surgery shops that are riding the wave of young India. One would imagine that spas and salons are for the overstressed working professional of today, but most spas claim that 15-20 per cent of their clients are pre-teens and teenagers. The Vedic Village's medical spa in Kolkata, Sanjeeva, has an ayurvedic package called the Dinacharya course that they especially recommend to teens. It is a residential package that costs Rs 3,000 a day, which combines medical solutions, yoga and naturopathy. Others, like Rudra Spa in Mumbai, are blatant about targeting teens. Says Dharram Pratap, CEO of Rudra Spa: "We are trying to build loyalty with the

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DR SURYAKANT KULKARNI,
ORTHOPAEDIC SURGEON



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